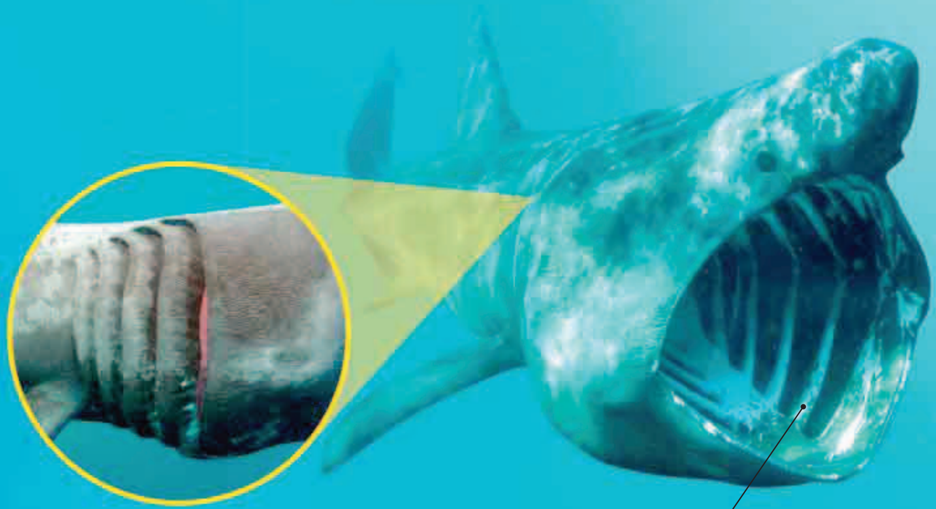
Filter-feeding giants

The biggest fish in the sea are not sharp-toothed hunters, but placid, slow-moving animals that feed by straining plankton-rich seawater for food. They use the same filter-feeding system as schooling fish such as herring and anchovy, allowing the water to flow through their gills so the food is trapped by their tough gill rakers.



BASKING SHARK

Three of the giant filter feeders are sharks—the basking shark, whale shark, and megamouth shark. The basking shark feeds in cool oceans, which are often cloudy with plankton. When feeding, it swims with its mouth wide open so the plankton-rich water flows through the mesh of gill rakers. These trap the food, while the water flows out through the huge gill slits at the back of the shark's head.

▲ GILL SLITS
The gill slits are unusual, in that they are so big, they almost encircle the neck.

Gill rakers protect gills and trap food

Prominent ridges along its body

RECORD BREAKER

The basking shark is a giant fish that can grow to an enormous 26 ft (8 m) long, but it is dwarfed by the whale shark. This tropical plankton feeder may be up to 46 ft (14 m) long. Like the basking shark, the whale shark catches its food by straining water through its gill rakers, but it does this by actively taking a mouthful of water, closing its mouth, and forcing the water out through its gills.

▲ WHALE SHARK
A diver swims alongside the colossal but harmless whale shark. This fish travels huge distances across warm oceans in search of plankton-rich waters.